The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump wrote on social media that a “whole civilisation will die tonight, never to be brought back again” unless **Iran** reopens the Strait of Hormuz with America by 8pm Eastern Time. **Pakistan’s** prime minister, Shehbaz Sharif, whose country has been acting as a mediator, urged Mr Trump to extend his deadline by two weeks. It remained unclear whether negotiations were still under way.

America attacked **Kharg Island**, the site of Iran’s main oil-export terminal. Missiles hit an airport, a dock and a base belonging to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. Israel intensified its assault, too, targeting railways and bridges. It also struck a **synagogue** in Tehran, Iran’s capital, and expressed regret for what it called “collateral damage”.

Mr Trump’s threats against Iran drew criticism from across the political spectrum. Ron Johnson, a **Republican** senator from Wisconsin and an ally of Mr Trump, warned that striking civilian infrastructure would be a “huge mistake”. Chuck Schumer, the Senate’s top Democrat, called Mr Trump “extremely sick”. Even abroad, **Nigel Farage**, leader of Britain’s Reform UK party, said the rhetoric had gone “too far”.

Intel announced it would join **Elon Musk's** Terafab project. The chipmaker will partner with Tesla, SpaceX and xAI to help Mr Musk manufacture his own chips for robotics and data centres in space. Intel's shares rose by nearly 5% before falling following the announcement. Meanwhile, SpaceX is expected to list its shares in the largest initial public offering of all time this year.

Novo Nordisk, a Danish drugmaker, released a stronger version of its weight-loss drug, **Wegovy**, in America. It will be sold for 40% less than **Zepbound**, made by Novo's American rival, Eli Lilly, and contains three times the dose of its previous formulation. Novo has recently lost ground to Lilly; Zepbound previously outperformed Wegovy, and outsells it by more than two to one in America.

Pershing Square Capital, a hedge fund, offered to buy **Universal Music Group** in a deal which values the world's largest music label at $64bn. Universal's shares, which had fallen by over 30% in the past six months over worries that AI-generated music could saturate the music industry and reduce profits, jumped by over 10% in early trading. The deal is expected to be completed by the end of the year.

Wireless Festival, a big music event in London due to happen in July, was cancelled after the British government denied its headline act, Ye, entry into Britain. The rapper, formerly known as **Kanye West**, has made antisemitic statements in the past and released a song called "Heil Hitler". He has since apologised for his "actions". Ye said that he still hopes to have a "conversation with the Jewish community" in Britain.

Figure of the day: 17%, the percentage of Americans who bet on a sporting event last year, more than double the rate two years earlier. Read the full story.

Photograph: AP

Trump threatens war crimes in Iran

Donald Trump has vowed to bomb Iran hard enough to send it “back to the Stone Ages”. On Saturday he gave Iran a 48-hour deadline to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, an ultimatum Iran has so far dismissed. A day later America’s president announced his next targets: “Tuesday will be Power Plant Day, and Bridge Day, all wrapped up in one.”

Such attacks could amount to serious war crimes. Power plants and other civilian infrastructure are generally protected under the laws of war. These sites can lose that protection if they are used for military purposes, but only if their destruction provides a “military advantage” that outweighs civilian harm; America’s armed forces usually determine the legality of any strikes on a case-by-case basis. Mr Trump’s suggestion that “each and every one” of Iran’s power plants be hit “simultaneously” would cause considerable suffering among the country’s 93m people. By any reading of the laws of war, that is the definition of an indiscriminate attack.

Photograph: Reuters

A MAGA pilgrimage to Budapest

J.D. Vance, America's vice-president, arrived in Budapest on Tuesday to show his support for Viktor Orban, Hungary's prime minister, ahead of parliamentary elections on April 12th. Most opinion polls show Mr Orban's party, Fidesz, well behind its upstart challenger, Tisza, led by a former Fidesz man, Peter Magyar.

Mr Orban has fostered close ties with leading figures on the American right ever since his party won election in 2010. His government financed the Danube Institute, a conservative think-tank, to export its hard-right politics around the world. For MAGA Republicans Mr Orban is a model to emulate: a scourge of the woke, a defender of borders, tradition and Christianity.

In Budapest, Mr Vance praised him as a "statesman" and attacked European Union "bureaucrats" for undermining Hungary. He even phoned Donald Trump during a rally, broadcasting the president's support for Mr Orban. The Hungarian leader might have preferred Mr Trump in person. But with polls pointing the other way, America's president is known to stay away from losers.

Photograph: Reuters

Taiwan’s opposition leader visits China

On Tuesday the leader of Taiwan’s main opposition party, Cheng Li-wun, travelled to China at the invitation of President Xi Jinping—the first such trip in a decade. The Kuomintang (KMT) and the Chinese Communist Party were once sworn enemies. Now China sees the KMT as its best chance of peacefully reuniting the island with the mainland. Ms Cheng has frequently asserted that both sides of the Taiwan Strait are part of “one China”.

If Ms Cheng were to make similar comments during a formal visit to the mainland it would be a coup for China’s propaganda machine. Ms Cheng’s movements are being closely watched in America, too, where a bipartisan group of senators has been urging Taiwan’s parties to unite behind a proposed $40bn increase in defence spending, which Ms Cheng is blocking. But in roughly a month there is a summit planned between Donald Trump and Mr Xi, at which China’s president is expected to press for reduced American arms sales to Taiwan.

Photograph: Getty Images

A bond market tug of war

Governments' borrowing costs have been in flux almost everywhere. In the turmoil of the Iran war bond yields first soared—reaching highs not seen in Britain since 2008 or Japan since 1997—before falling back last week.

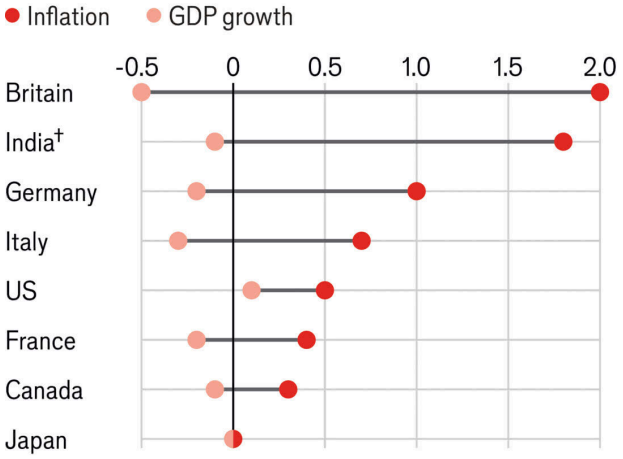
Optimists might conclude that yields have dropped because hostilities will soon end, allowing oil to flow freely through the Strait of Hormuz. But optimists generally do not pursue careers in bond investing. In the case of the Iran war, the job means fretting about stagflation: economic stagnation combined with high inflation. Borrowing costs are whipsawing because these two dangers tug them in opposite directions.

Governments most exposed to inflationary pressure from Hormuz's closure have seen their yields jump highest (Britain, India). Early in the war traders bet that the Federal Reserve would stop cutting rates to contain the inflationary effects of the energy shock. Now they expect cuts again to promote growth—something that could exacerbate inflation. The longer Hormuz stays shut the higher the stakes get.

Fire and ice

Cumulative change in 2026 and 2027 forecasts*

Percentage points



*Forecasts made in Mar 2026 compared with Dec 2025 †Fiscal years beginning April

Source: OECD

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which political party won the largest share of the vote in the recent Baden-Wũrttemburg regional election?

Monday: Who is the president of the European Central Bank?

A business that makes nothing but money is a poor business.

Henry Ford